

THE SOLUTIONS

- Treat public transport as an essential service, not a profit-making enterprise
- Ensure sustained funding to maintain fleets, improve frequency and make services reliable
- Integrate buses with metros, railways and other modes through better feeder connectivity



"Give strategic levers to people to shift to public transit. They don't want to stand in lines, walk two km or take a rickshaw. So, quality becomes equally important, if we have to make public transit more efficient"

— ANURAG GUPTA
Partner, Deloitte India

India's operational metro network had reached 1,185 km across 26 cities. By early this year, nine metro projects covering approximately 174 km had been approved at a combined capital cost exceeding Rs 59,000 crore.

But investment alone does not guarantee a higher public transport share. "We had a target that people may not know about: public transport, including the metro, was supposed to achieve up to a 75 per cent mode share. It was a very good target, but it never went above about 61 per cent," says P.K. Sarkar, transport expert and former professor, School of Planning and Architecture, Delhi. "Whenever we work out public transport requirements for a city, we work against a benchmark. But people in power often bargain that number down. Some say why 100, just 50 buses are enough. That mindset has to change first."

Investment in buses is also increasing, but translating sanctioned fleets into services remains a challenge. Under the PM eBus Sewa scheme, 10,000 buses have been sanctioned for 115 cities. The latest data: 1,100 buses are operational in 28 cities, with the capacity to carry 250,000-odd passengers daily. The scheme provides operating support of Rs 24 per km for standard 12-metre buses.

Making Buses Work

But running a dependable service requires drivers, depots, maintenance facilities, appropriate routes and frequencies and seamless connections with other modes of transport.

Singapore's Land Transport Authority manages bus routes via performance-based fees: operators must deliver at least 96 per cent of scheduled mileage, with punctuality and waiting times monitored; payments depend on service, not just ticket revenue. Replicating this in India is hindered by fragmented administration across city buses, state undertakings, metros and suburban railways, each with separate agencies, budgets and priorities.

The Union cabinet's October 6 decision to set up an Integrated Transport and Logistics Authority could help address this issue. It will prepare a National Transport Master Plan, covering a decade, coordinate planning across ministries, approve projects worth over Rs 500 crore and review their performance.

But a national framework alone cannot ensure that a city bus connects with a metro arrival or that an intercity passenger finds reliable onward transport. Such coordination requires planning at the city and regional levels. Something we lack currently. ■

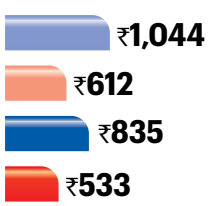
—Avishek G. Dastidar

THE PRICE OF MOBILITY

Urban Rural Male Female

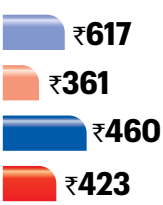
FOR WORKERS

₹785
Average monthly expenditure of commuting to a fixed workplace



FOR STUDENTS

₹443
Average monthly cost of trips to and from educational institutions





₹2,165
Average monthly commute expenditure of a male worker travelling to a fixed workplace in Arunachal Pradesh, the highest among states/UTs

"Affordability and accessibility are the key for economic activity. Good public transport means higher productivity"



— SHIVANAND SWAMY, *Senior Mobility Expert, CEPT University, Ahmedabad*



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR